

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 14
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Understanding Community
30 August 2026



Out Chorus
Romare Bearden, 1980

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: LVF & Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz

STRIPS OF PAPER IN PROGRAM FOR PRAYERS

Piano and amplification with monitors for choir and piano

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on DOWN BY THE RIVERSIDE and WHEN THE SAINTS GO MARCHING IN

Meditation on PRECIOUS LORD, TAKE MY HAND

Ecclusiastics (Charles Mingus, arr. C. Bull)

Medley of Spirituals:

WADE IN THE WATER

I WANT JESUS TO WALK WITH ME

I'VE GOT PEACE LIKE A RIVER

German Folk Song Arrangement (Christoph Bull)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura, Ianthe, and Jay center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

LVF: Today we acknowledge the collective loss we feel for two great humanitarians, artists, and stalwart advocates for the LGBTQ communities and the marginalized: **Dolly Parton and Tim Curry. Join us again next Sunday September 6th where we will pay tribute to Dolly's music.**

Words of Gathering

IM & JPC

Accompanied by Jordan Leicht, *Saxophone* and Christoph Bull, *Piano*

Jay: Listen: the fingerprints, footprints, and soul-prints of the Creator, have put their mark on us as we begin our time together on this day... *[brief improv]*

Ianthe: As children of the Most High, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:
A journey to the heart of life, to the center of God's awesome creation, to the intersection of holy moments. [brief improv]

Jay: As siblings of the Christ, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:
A journey to the edge of life, to the boundaries of the human condition, to the intersection of holy moments. [brief improv]

Ianthe: As children and siblings, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:
A journey to the in-between places of life: the encounters, confrontations, serendipities, the intersection of holy moments. [brief improv]

Jay: As a people gathered from near and far, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:
Let us begin anew, here and now, in this place and time. Let this be an intersection of holy moments. Let this be our act of thankfulness for the grace and goodness of this life together!

Ianthe: May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Jay: *Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering*

***Hymn of Gathering** *When the Saints Go Marching In*
Oh when the saints go marchin in, Oh when the saints go marchin in
Oh how I want to be in that number, when the saints go marchin in

Oh when the sun refuse to shine, oh when the sun refuse to shine
Oh how I want to be in that number, when the sun refuse to shine

Oh when that horn begins to sound, oh when that horn begins to sound
Oh how I want to be in that number, when that horn begins to sound

Oh when the saints go marchin in, Oh when the saints go marchin in
Oh how I want to be in that number, when the saints go marchin in

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

LVF

Let us pray together:

Creator God, maker of dancing stars and moonlit summer nights,
sender of gentle breezes and swirling winds,
finder of lost opportunities and mender of broken dreams,
you bless our lives with holy possibilities, beckoning us on a journey with you –
and your still-speaking voice.

Compassionate God, you know us inside and out.
When our hearts sigh with grief too large to carry—you are there.
When our tears flow like angry streams—you are there.
When doubts snare us like a trap—you are there.
When hope dwindles to a thin strand—you are there.

Gracious and Loving God, you know our comings and our goings.
You know when we fail and when we find success.
You know the deepest longings of our hearts.
Through it all, your love surrounds us, embraces us, sustains us,
and opens our eyes to the wondrous possibilities you place before us.

*In the promise of this moment, Holy One, speak to us anew
that we might capture the vision for living fully
as your children, whose love and strength,
will help nurture freedom and community in our world.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

Won't You Be My Neighbor? Fred Rogers, arr. Katelyn Dietz
Katelyn Dietz & Molly Pease, *Soloists*, Jordan Leicht, *Saxophone*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Rhythm Section*

[Jay to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

JPC

Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

Let us pause . . .
for a brief moment, and cease our frantic pace
Let us imagine . . .
the possibilities for being our authentic selves
Let us create . . .
a space for our Muses and be open to discovering our creativity
Let us become . . .
catalysts—dance, sculpt, sing, play our holy art for the world.

And as we pause, imagine, create, and become more of who we truly are...

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Jay to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

from Psalm 148

JPC

Let us together share in this beautiful rendering of Psalm 148 by Nan Merrill...

Let all people praise the Beloved,
who is exalted in heaven
and on earth;
whose glory is above
heaven and earth.

For all are to be called friends,
companions to the true Friend,
giving their lives joyfully
as co-creators and
people of peace.

***Praise to the Blessed One,
the very Breath of our breath,
the very Heart of our heart.***

For this chorus of the ancients...
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Laura center chancel]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

As we come to this time of silence and prayer,
listen now to these words from Joyce Rupp,
as our invitation to open our hearts, our minds,
and our bodies, to the Holy One...
wait three seconds

You are the One sent to free us
from inner and outer oppression,
to liberate us from our illusions
and anything taking us from you,
assisting us to recover our ability
to be people of loving kindness.
You have shown us the clear way
and have loved us back into life.

And you will wait
for as long as it takes
for us to accept your gift of freedom.

- Joyce Rupp

Invitation to write prayers and bring them forward to the bowl and to light candles.
Online folx, please email yours to prayers@fccla.org

Let us now be in silence, together...

[Laura to seat]

Silence

[Christoph transition out of silence and play as people come forward to offer Prayers]

[Laura center chancel when all are seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

from Psalm 119

LVF

Holy One, you whisper our names, inviting us to dream, to wonder,
to be filled with awe as their holy possibilities appear on our horizons.
*In this sacred time and space, we wonder, individually and collectively,
if this time of holy possibility is truly meant for each one of us.*

Trusting in the wisdom of the ancestors who have gone before us,
this morning we open our minds, our hearts, and our bodies to you, Holy One;
You are here and available for each one of us, for all of us,
and in this time, anything is possible.

All of us?

Yes, all of us, and as we breathe together, may we begin to expect the impossible.

*Are we sure it is for all of us? The proud and the strong, the lost and the searching,
the joyous and the sad?*

Absolutely! Breathe in together and begin to experience the impossible.

All of us...word-arrangers and finger-painters, rope-jumpers and slow-walkers, belly-laughers and soul-singers?

Yes! Breathe in together and begin to live the impossible.

Here and now, O Holy One, break into our experience,
take our hands, and call us again into the heart of life on this journey
we are privileged to share.

May it be so.

*May it be so for all of us,
gathered here in this time and place, together.*

[Christoph transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem *Precious Lord, Take My Hand* Thomas Dorsey, arr. Arnold Sevier
Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon *Understanding Community* **ML**

[Christoph transition Jay to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity JPC

The dreams and visions that we have for this place we all call home, are continually blessing our times together, even as we continue stretching toward that, which is yet to come.

We invite you to be part of what is happening in this place, through the giving of your time, your skills, your talent, your creativity, your energy - and yes - your financial resources. We depend on all the gifts you bring to this sacred dream and we are thankful for who the Holy is gathering, to do this work together.

You may give by using the QR Code in your programs and appearing now on your screens if you are watching online. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward to receive your gifts.

Offertory Anthem Take 5 Paul Desmond/Douglas E. Wagner
Bell Choir, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*, Jordan Leicht, *Alto Saxophone*

[All turn towards altar]

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Jay to lectern]

***Offering Prayer** **JPC**

Good and Gracious God, we are overflowing with gratitude for the ways in which you continue to co-create the present,

and the future, with us.

We ask that you help us discern and come to know -
all that is happening around us, among us, and within us,
as we journey together, guided by your light and your love.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Michael & Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

LVF: Fall Series begins next week, *Painting the Stars!* [share about it]

ML: Our regular choral season starts up again this coming Thursday, September 3rd. This season, our choir will be directed by Dr. Ianthe and Dr. Fahad as the Interim Directors of Music and Arts. Rehearsals are from 7-9 pm on Thursday evenings and childcare is provided in Wong Chapel. If you have always wondered about singing in the choir and wish to check it out, please email Ianthe at imarini@fccla.org.

LVF:

Words of Blessing

ML

Please join me now for these Words of Blessing...

That when freedom comes
we will open our eyes
to see it.

***That when freedom shows up
we will let ourselves
be overcome
not by fear
but by the love
it bears.***

That when freedom shines
we will bring it
with us
***all the way
all the way
all the way home.*** [adapt/jrichardson]

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response *Down by the Riverside* African-American Spiritual arr. Moses Hogan
Brandon Harris, *Soloist* Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

***Hymn for the Journey** *Down by the Riverside*
GONNA LAY DOWN MY SWORD AND SHIELD

Gonna lay down my burden
Down by the riverside, down by the riverside, down by the riverside.
Gonna lay down my burden
Down by the riverside, and study war no more.

Chorus I ain't gonna study war no more, ain't gonna study war no more,
Ain't gonna study war no more.
I ain't gonna study war no more, ain't gonna study war no more,
Ain't gonna study war no more!

Gonna lay down my sword and shield
Down by the riverside, down by the riverside, down by the riverside
Gonna lay down my sword and shield
Down by the riverside, and study war no more.

Chorus

Gonna walk down that road of peace
Down by the riverside, down by the riverside, down by the riverside
Gonna walk down that road of peace
Down by the riverside, and study war no more.

Chorus

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Allegro Agitato in G minor: Davy Jones plays his Organ (Hans Zimmer, adapted for Organ by C. Bull)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music Dr. Ianthe Marini

My childhood best friend moved to New Orleans in the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina, feeling called to help rebuild its community. Her time with the *Habitat for Humanity* led her to a group of musicians who introduced her to the rich and diverse cultural ecosystem and musical landscape of the city. She forged an alliance with the lawyers in the area and has been fighting against those who have sought to gentrify downtown with noise ordinances and music curfews. In an interview with the city she stated, *"If you don't want to hear music into the night...then don't move to Downtown New Orleans. You must understand the community in which you live, not wish to alter that which defines it."*

On this August 30th, the 21st anniversary of Hurricane Katrina, we remember this rich diverse community by celebrating the cultural ecosystem of its music that has defined our country.

“American music culture IS Black culture”, says rapper Yelawolf, reflecting on the recognition that the music of our country does not exist without the rhythms, melodies, harmonies, and spirits sung by those enslaved by her, brought to her shores in chains, made to build this nation against their will, and reclaiming their humanity and spirit through song: the ultimate act of resilience and resistance. These songs of the enslaved, coming from the body and the breath to reclaim that those bodies and that breath is human, became the African-American spirituals to gospel to blues to jazz to country music to rock and roll to pop music that we know today. Indeed, American culture IS Black culture.

It is for this reason that today at First Church, as we explore the theme of *Understanding Community*, we centralize the rich diversity of music from the Black tradition. *Precious Lord, take my hand*, wrote Thomas Dorsey in his desperate musical plea in the aftermath of great personal loss. Set masterfully by the great Gospel pianist Arnold Sevier in our arrangement today, we repeat the phrase *take my hand, take my hand, take my hand*—the only way to build community together. We continue by singing and playing music of the jazz tradition as we highlight the many iterations of ensemble community here at this church: with bell choir and saxophone soloist as they *Take 5*, with solo singers and jazz combo as they beckon us to community together— *Won't you be my neighbor?*, and with full chorus as we harken back to the music from which jazz ultimately came: the African-American spiritual. *Gonna walk down that road of peace down by the Riverside where we will study war no more*. Let us continue to seek understanding of our community, growing ever into her authentic potential.